

Vegetarian and Vegan Nutrition

Vegetarian Nutrition

A well-planned vegetarian diet can support:

- muscle gain;
- fat loss;
- weight maintenance;
- athletic performance.

Useful vegetarian protein sources include:

- milk;
- curd or yogurt;
- paneer;
- eggs if included;
- soy;
- tofu;
- tempeh;
- lentils;
- chickpeas;
- beans;
- peas;
- nuts;
- seeds;
- whole grains.

Nutrients that may require additional attention depending on the diet include:

- protein;
- iron;
- vitamin B12;
- calcium;
- vitamin D;
- omega-3 fatty acids.

Vegetarian does not automatically mean healthy. A vegetarian diet can still be dominated by:

- refined grains;
- sweets;
- fried foods;

- low-protein meals.

Vegan Nutrition

A well-planned vegan diet can support exercise and fitness.

Particular attention should be paid to:

- total protein;
- protein variety;
- vitamin B12;
- calcium;
- iron;
- iodine;
- vitamin D;
- omega-3 fatty acids.

Useful vegan protein sources include:

- soybeans;
- tofu;
- tempeh;
- lentils;
- chickpeas;
- beans;
- peas;
- seitan where available;
- soy milk;
- plant protein powders.

Vitamin B12

Vitamin B12 is naturally concentrated in animal-derived foods.

People following vegan diets need a reliable source of vitamin B12 from:

- fortified foods;
- appropriate supplementation.

Iron

Plant-based sources of iron include:

- lentils;
- beans;

- chickpeas;
- leafy green vegetables;
- fortified foods.

Vitamin C can improve absorption of non-heme iron from plant foods.

Useful pairings include:

- dal with lemon;
- chickpeas with tomato;
- beans with capsicum;
- iron-containing meals with fruit rich in vitamin C.

Calcium

Plant-based calcium sources include:

- fortified plant milk;
- calcium-set tofu;
- sesame products;
- certain leafy green vegetables;
- fortified foods.

Omega-3 Fatty Acids

Plant sources of alpha-linolenic acid include:

- flaxseed;
- chia seeds;
- walnuts.

Algae-derived supplements can provide long-chain omega-3 fatty acids for people who do not consume fish.

Protein Quality

Many plant proteins provide all essential amino acids but in different proportions.

A varied diet across the day can provide the required amino acids.

Examples of useful combinations include:

- rice with dal;
- roti with chickpeas;
- beans with grains.

It is not necessary to combine complementary proteins at every single meal.

Example High-Protein Vegetarian Foods

Approximate protein content varies by product and portion size, but useful options include:

- paneer;
- Greek-style yogurt or strained curd;
- milk;
- eggs;
- tofu;
- soy chunks;
- lentils;
- chickpeas;
- kidney beans;
- peanuts;
- whey protein.

Example High-Protein Vegan Foods

Useful options include:

- tofu;
- tempeh;
- soy chunks;
- soy milk;
- lentils;
- chickpeas;
- kidney beans;
- peas;
- seitan;
- pea protein;
- soy protein;
- blended plant protein powders.